

work out for me, but it's worth the time it takes to ask the question.

37. Be willing to substitute expensive flowers for cheaper ones with the same look

My wedding was in California, within a week of the Rose Parade. Many of the flowers I'd planned on having were sold out, because someone used them in a float. I was a little nervous about letting my florist make substitutions, but she did really well and the overall effect was still what I wanted. Also, it ended up being cheaper because she used some more obscure blooms.

38. Let your florist make the decisions

She is the professional, after all. I told my florist the overall look I wanted, my colors, and the fact that I was trying to save money, and then I let her make the decisions. The flowers couldn't have been better if they'd been all exotic blooms!

39. Simple elegance beats (and is less expensive than) lots of frills

Enter Sarah's Soapbox: Some florists want to add frills (extra bows, pearls,

pieces of lace) at a substantial extra cost. Don't let them. Flowers should look like flowers, not frosted replicas of themselves. Besides, flowers are cheaper than bows, pearls, and lace.

40. Dried flowers are perfect!

My favorite scent is lavender, so I used dried lavender as one of the unifying themes of the wedding. The flower girls threw it, the church and hall were decorated with it, and the guests threw it at us as we left. It was cheaper than using real flowers in all of those areas, and united the different parts of our wedding festivities in a way I wouldn't have thought possible.

41. Find people who grow the flowers you want in their yards

Ask several of them if you can cut a few. True story: My friend got married in Seattle, where purple hydrangeas grow well. Her florist wanted to charge a ton for them, so she and her sister went door to door where they saw them growing, asking if they could come back and cut two or three blossoms the day before the wedding. So many people agreed to it that she had more flowers than she needed, all for the expense of a little legwork!